formed one class and there was hardly any specialization. T h e word *Arya* comes f r o m a root word meaning to till, and the Aryans as a whole were agriculturists and agriculture was considered a noble occupation. T h e tiller of the soil functioned also as priest, soldier, or trader, and there was no privileged order of priests. T h e caste divisions, originally intended to separate the Aryans from the non-Aryans, reacted on the Aryans themselves, and as division of functions and specialization increased, the new classes took the form of castes.

Thus at a time when it was customary for the conquerors to exterminate or enslave the conquered races, caste enabled a more peaceful solution which fitted in with the growing specialization of functions. Life was graded and out of the mass of agriculturists evolved the *Vaishyas,* the agriculturists, artisans, and merchants; the *Kshatriyas,* or rulers and warriors; and the *Brahmins,* priests a n d thinkers who were supposed to guide policy and preserve and maintain the ideals of the nation. Below these three were the *Shudras* or labourers and unskilled workers, other than the agriculturists. Among the indigenous tribes many were gradually assimilated and given a place at the bottom of the social scale,